

Health Research Ethics

Wits/Aberdeen University 2-day training
Mpumalanga Health Research Committee
Mpumalanga Department of Health

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Module IV Contemporary issues



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What does this training cover?

Module I: Health research, ethical principles

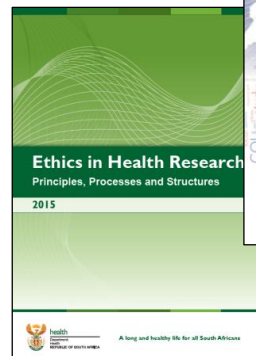
Module II: Norms, standards, and criteria

Module III: Research governance and RECs

Module IV: Contemporary issues

Module V: Monitoring research conduct

Not specifically covered: Biological materials/Human tissue; Clinical/medical ethics, therapeutics; Genetics/genomics research but principles apply



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Module IV

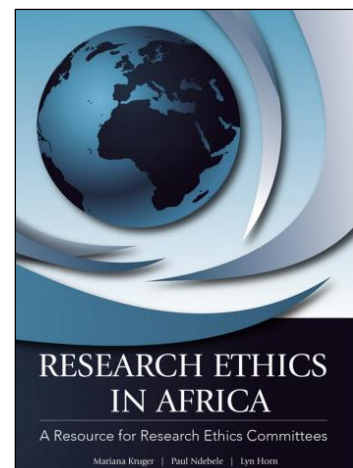
Contemporary issues: Who counts?
Knowledge and power in global health;
data and evidence systems; and the
decolonisation imperative

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Module IV Learning Outcomes

- a) Relate decolonialisation to research governance
- b) Orient to emerging research paradigms
- c) Familiarise with open science/open research

Plenary: Adaptive research governance in PHRC



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4a | Decolonising global health research

“ethical review originates in the US, ...regulating medical doctors’ research on their patients. Nowadays ethical review process acts as a safeguard against exploitation of research participants, determining what is acceptable behaviour or methodology ...

Yet, there remains much work to be done to make the process suitable for non-medical and non-Western contexts.... While ethical review is needed ... **we must also take seriously the research ethics framework’s limitations”**

[Chaurey, 2020](#)



“Research and researcher increasingly require decolonization so that research can create a positive impact on the participants’ community, and conduct research ethically”

[Datta, 2019](#)



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Decolonisation, some terms

- **Colonisation/Colonialism:** taking over someone else’s land, people and resources
- **Post-colonial:** effects profound, engaging with consequences of colonialism
- **Neo-colonialism:** continuation of structures/relations of **extraction, dispossession and imposition**
- **Decolonization:** fighting exploitation, extraction, dispossession, and imposition of one way of knowing/governing

“Colonization models are ... perpetuated by fellow citizens, former colonizers, and other external actors, as well as through institutions of global governance”

“...reconnect with local configurations, ... break with sterile imitation, ... adapt science, technology and research to our context, ... elaborate institutions on the basis of our specificities and our resources, .. adopt an inclusive governance framework and endogenous development, to create value in Africa .”

Source: Atuire & Rutazibwa 2021



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Who's values? Who's driving the agenda? "An inclusive governance framework"

...we need to think carefully about different interpretations of value concepts such as **solidarity**, and it's a good example of a relatively recent recognition in 'mainstream' academic bioethics that **western analytic philosophy is not the only source for identifying and understanding value concepts** and developing good ethical reasoning

Entwistle 2021

Governance structures must be **adaptive** to embrace new developments in science.

...Opportunities that accrue from collaborative research need to be seized through strong MoH leadership and clear partnership frameworks that guide negotiations [Nabyonga-Orem, 2021](#)

Nabyonga-Orem et al. Health Res Policy Sys (2021) 19:11
<https://doi.org/10.1186/s12961-020-00676-9>

Health Research Policy
and Systems

RESEARCH

Open Access

The state of health research governance in Africa: what do we know and how can we improve?

Juliet Nabyonga-Orem^{1*}, James Avoka Asamani¹ and Micheal Makanga²



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Driving the agenda 'adaptive governance'

- Provincial Research Committees
 - liaise with researchers
 - ensure greatest health needs of each province addressed
 - effect of research on services
 - Gate-keeping role in access to health facilities
- Consistent deliberative and decision-making about ethics
- Best ethical practices in research
- Compliance with national/international requirements
- Framework for South Africa-based research



NUFFIELD
COUNCIL ON
BIOETHICS

All countries should set **national priorities** for healthcare research. If external sponsors propose research which falls outside the national priorities, the research should be justified to the appropriate research ethics committees

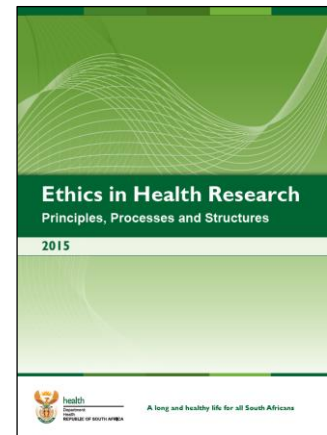
[Nuffield Council on Bioethics, 2002](#)

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Urgent need for African ethics



Vaccine inequity and injustice is not just a moral failure. It is also a health and economic catastrophe [WHO 2022](#)



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Resources

Decolonising Research Initiative



COMMENT

An African Reading of the Covid-19 pandemic and the stakes of decolonization

Caesar A Atuire & Olivia U Rutazibwa

July 2021

The Covid-19 pandemic has so far revealed that the virus (SARS-CoV-2) does not only infect, weaken, and highlight weaknesses in human biological systems, but also the structural weaknesses of health systems at international and national levels. We may paraphrase a famous quote from the late president of Ghana, Dr. Mohammed Bosman, by saying, "When the foundations of health are weak, Covid-19 will expose you." [1] Here, 'you' refers to the increasing vulnerability to external forces and the weathering of the, just like a virus infects a living body and thrives on biological 'weak fundamentals' such as underlying health conditions and age, pandemic(s) ravages and those on public health 'weak fundamentals' such as inequality, poverty, and discrimination.

out of Africa

Solidarity-Based Approach to Vaccine Allocation

JOYJECKER and CAESAR A. AUIRE

More than a pandemic, the Covid-19 crisis is a syndemic: a convergence of biosocial forces that produce widespread disease. To understand, it calls for justice viewed through a wide-angle lens that cares about more than health systems. One such approach can be developed out of a spirit of solidarity, which, fittingly, can be developed from the important African concept of ubuntu. This approach will prioritize vaccine distribution in low- and middle-income countries.

"Butterfly effect" in chaos theory refers to the widespread and unpredictable effects of changes to an initial set of conditions. The metaphor of a butterfly flapping its wings, and days or weeks later, in the timing, and path of a tornado. Like the butterfly effect, the humble origins of the disease have produced repercussions in far-flung places. The public emergence of the pandemic 2019 traces to a tiny mouse zoonotic jump in species, probably originating from an infection in an animal and ended up in a human, probably in Hubei, China. [2] Within a matter of weeks, that single zoonotic jump produced a global pandemic that has sickened more than 132 million people and led to the deaths of more than two million people. [3] Like the butterfly that changed the course of the pandemic, the tiny mouse spread the virus, livelihoods, and health of people everywhere.

The humble origins of the SARS-CoV-2 virus, the pathogen that causes Covid-19, are paradigmatic of a new era in health: most emerging human diseases are zoonotic and interact with people whose underlying health and social conditions create a 'perfect storm.' [4] According to findings from the 2020 Global Burden of Disease study, despite sustained improvements in public health in economically developing nations, such as reductions in household air pollution, child growth failure, unsafe water, sanitation, handwashing, and exposure to smoking, progress stalled in economically developed

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4b | Emerging paradigms: Health policy and systems research (HPSR)

- How societies organise in achieving health goals
- How actors interact in policy and implementation
- How health systems respond and adapt to health policies
- Research 'with' not 'on' stakeholders

Sources: [Gilson, 2012](#); [WHO 2019](#)



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Embeddedness

- "...embedding of research in real world policy, practice and implementation is needed to strengthen health systems worldwide (Ghaffar et al 2017)
- "when embedding happens, researchers and decision makers are linked through a systems in which the need for evidence to inform policy is understood by decision makers" (WHO, 2012)
- Insider research: inside systems
- Changeable, flexible and adaptable process
- Interdisciplinary and intersectional
- Highly relational
- Aligned with local priorities
- Locally driven, locally owned
- Democratises research process

Source: Olivier 2017

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Participatory/cooperative

- Those affected are primary source of information & primary actors in generating, validating and using knowledge for action
- Process sensitive to context & shifts power towards those most directly affected
- Disrupts subject/object distinction
- Collective enquiry
- Organises experiential knowledge
- Transformative function



“Understand the world by trying to change it”

Source: [Loewenson et al 2014](#)

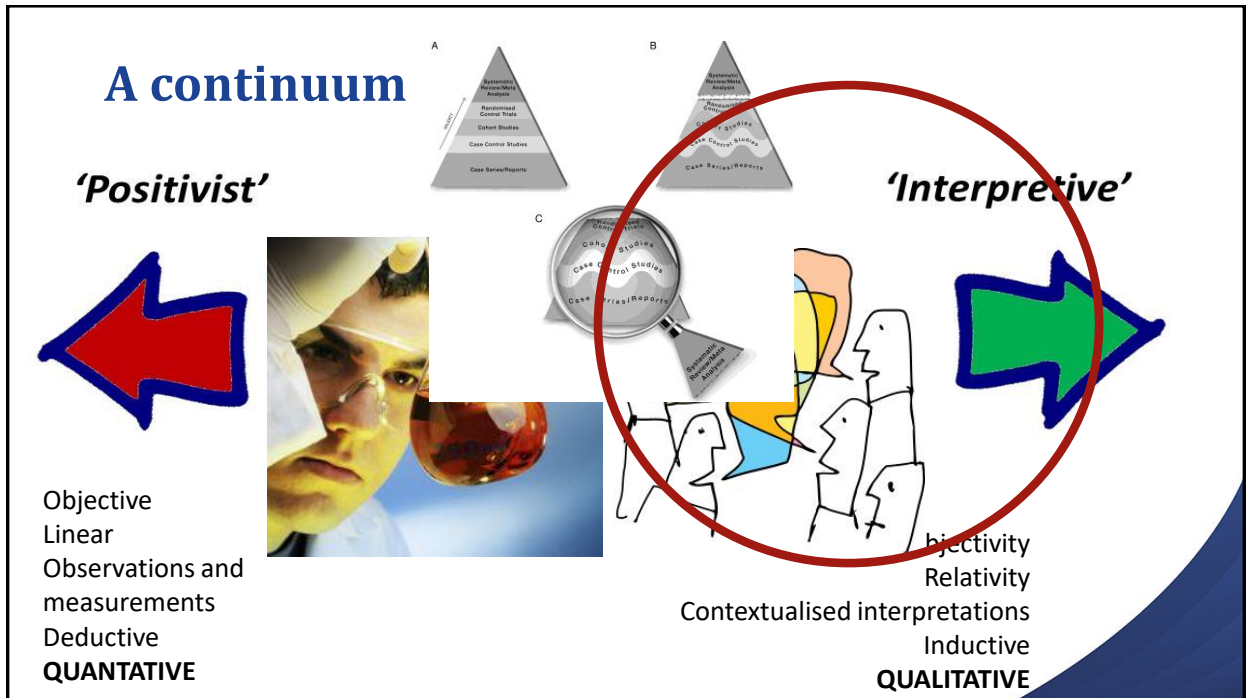
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Participatory research

- **Positioning of researchers:** Relationships with communities. Strong interpersonal + social competencies are necessary
- **Time/resource demands:** enabling context + communications skills for mutual understanding + trust to develop
- **Power and consequences:** whose interests drive the process; privacy and protecting information; risks in participating in action phases



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4c | Open data

Developments, such as crowdsourcing, participatory surveillance, and individuals pledging to become “data donors” and the “quantified self” movement (where citizens share data through mobile device-connected technologies), have great potential to contribute to our knowledge of disease, improving diagnostics, and delivery of healthcare and treatment.

...also major concerns over privacy, confidentiality, and control of data about individuals once it is shared. Issues, such as user trust, data privacy, transparency over the control of data ownership, and the implications of data analytics for personal privacy with potentially intrusive inferences, are becoming increasingly scrutinized at national and international levels

[Kostkova et al, 2016](#)

frontiers
in Public Health

PERSPECTIVE
published: 17 February 2016
doi: 10.3389/fpubh.2016.00002

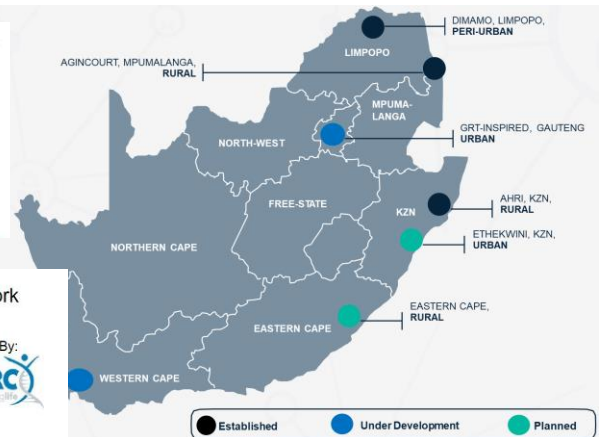


Who Owns the Data? Open Data for Healthcare

Patty Kostkova^{1*}, Helen Brewer², Simon de Lusignan³, Edward Fottrell⁴, Ben Goldacre⁵, Graham Hart⁶, Phil Koczar⁷, Peter Knight⁸, Corinne Manolter⁹, Rachel A. McKendry¹⁰, Emma Raza¹¹, Angela Sasse¹², Ralph Sullivan¹³, Sarah Chaytor¹⁴, Olivia Stevenson¹⁵, Raquel Velho¹⁶ and John Tooke¹⁷

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Big data



DSI-MRC South African Population Research Infrastructure Network



Health and Demographic Surveillance System (HDSS) Nodes:



Partner Universities:



stats sa

Department:
Statistics South Africa
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA

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Open research

Open research is [research](#) that is openly accessible and modifiable by others. Much like open-source schemes that are built around a [source code](#) that is made public, the central theme of open research is to make clear accounts of the methodology freely available via the internet, along with any data or results extracted or derived from them. This permits a massively distributed collaboration, and one in which anyone may participate at any level of the project (Wiki)



science & innovation

Department:
Science and Innovation
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA

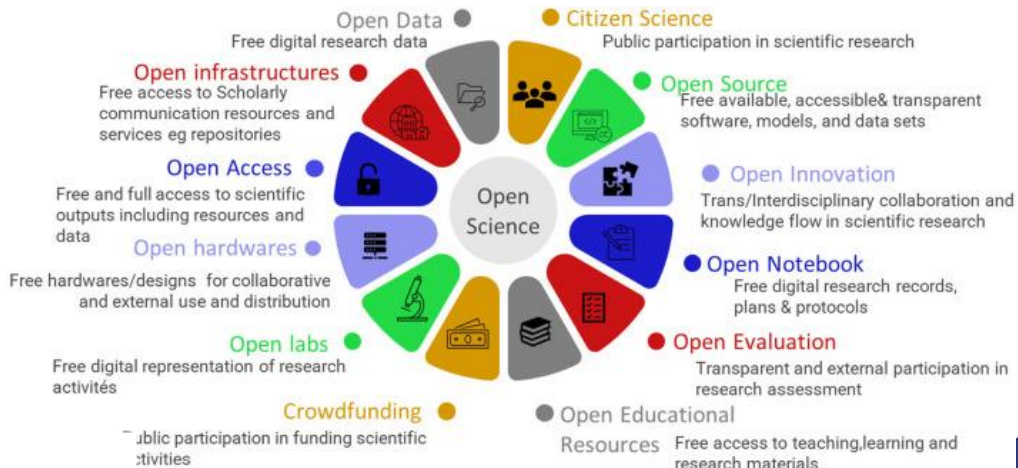
DRAFT NATIONAL OPEN SCIENCE POLICY

Draft 0 OPEN SCIENCE POLICY v19 - clean 24/01/2022

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Elements of open science (and why we need adaptive governance)



Adapted from UNESCO recommendation 2021

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Plenary: Decolonising research governance Adaptive governance in PHRC (30 mins)

1. How does one decolonize and reclaim the meanings of research and researcher?
2. Indigenous communities have long experienced oppression by Western researchers. Is it possible to build a collaborative research knowledge that is culturally appropriate, respectful, honouring, and careful of the Indigenous community?
3. What are the challenges in Western research, researchers, and Western university methodology research training?
4. How have 'studies' – critical anti-racist theory and practice, cross-cultural research methodology, critical perspectives on environmental justice, and land-based education – been incorporated into the [university] to disallow dissent? What can be done against this disallowance?

Source: Datta (2017)

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